

The Strategic Controller Playbook

Mastering Financial Workflows, Reporting, and Decision Support in Higher Education.



Translating raw data into actionable strategy.

Evolving from Financial Historian to Strategic Navigator

The Traditional View

What happened?

- Backward-looking
- Policing budgets
- Ensuring accounting compliance



The Modern UiA Controller

Why did it happen, and what should we do?

- Prognosis
- Forward-looking decision support
- Process optimization



Controls the numbers



Detects anomalies



Translates for leaders



Drives resolution

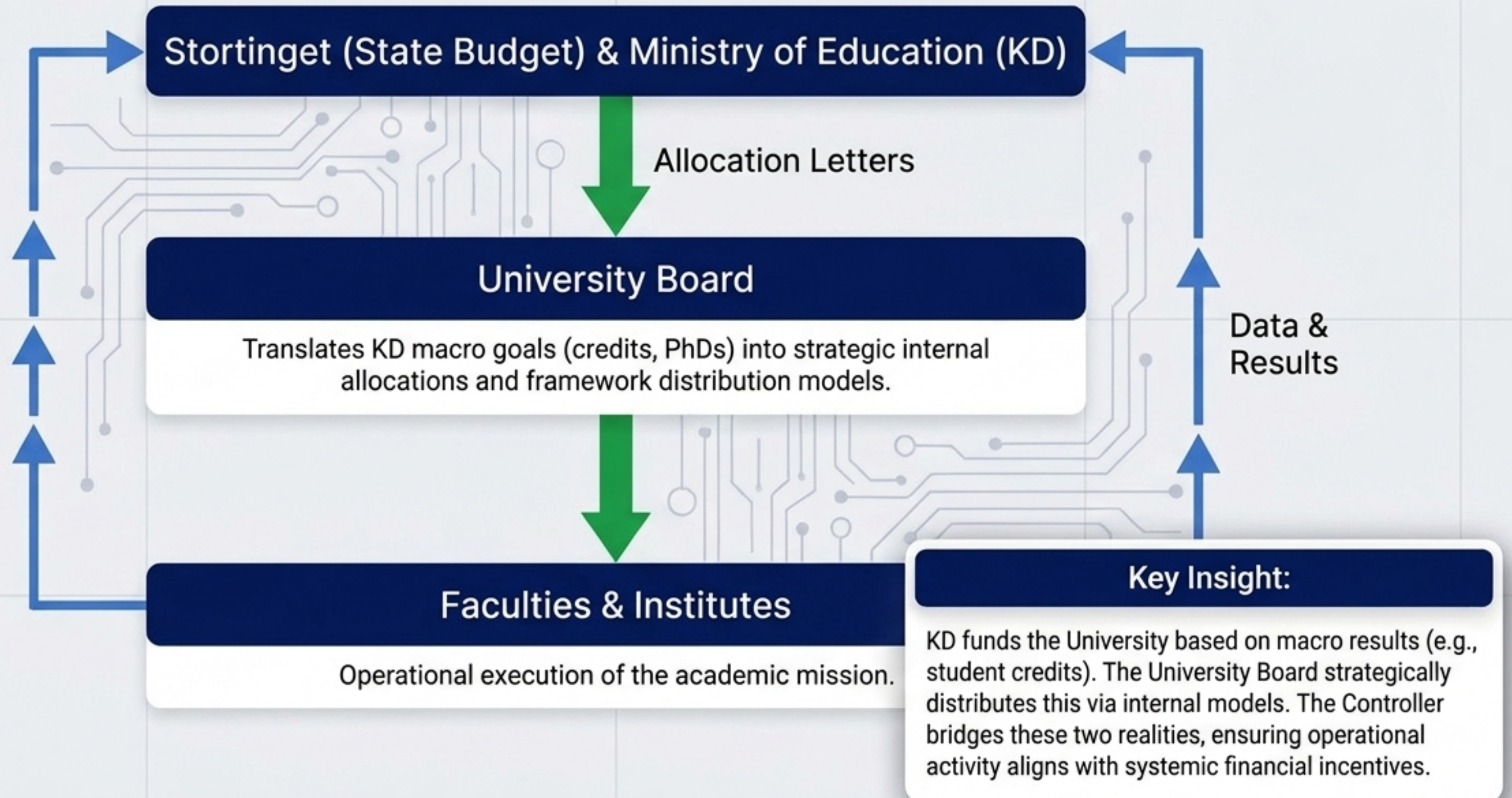


Ensures robust processes



Innovates digital workflows

Navigating the Higher Education Funding Ecosystem



Transitioning Accounting Frameworks: Municipal vs. State (SRS)

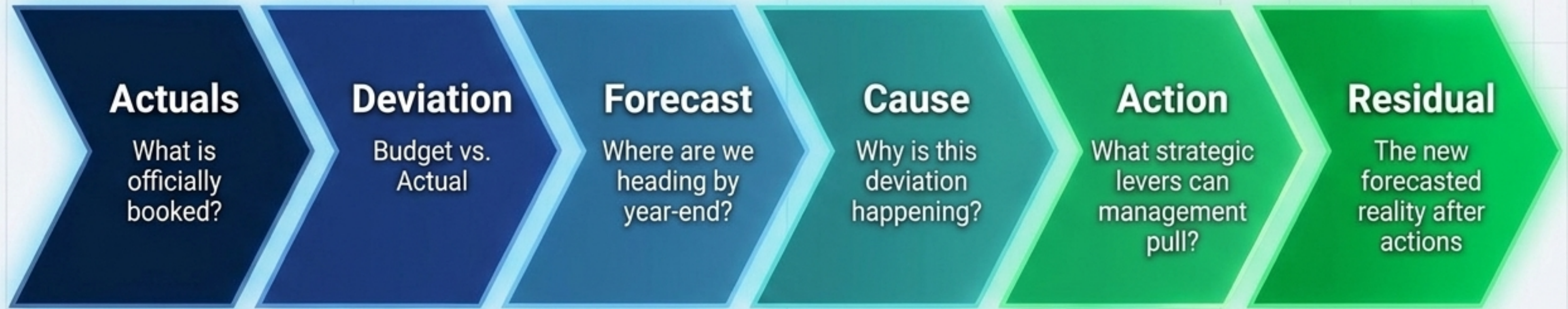
Dimension	KOSTRA / Municipal	SRS / State University
Primary Purpose	Service data comparison	Enterprise financial position
Accounting Logic	Municipal rules	Accrual principles (Periodization)
Classification	KOSTRA-functions	State standard accounts + Internal dimensions
Investments	Separate investment accounts	Balance sheet capitalization & depreciation
Result Focus	Focus on strict budget balance	Focus on actual resource consumption

SRS requires a business economic mindset: We don't just ask 'When do we pay?' but '**When is the resource consumed?**'

The Annual Controller Cadence and Strategic Steering Wheel

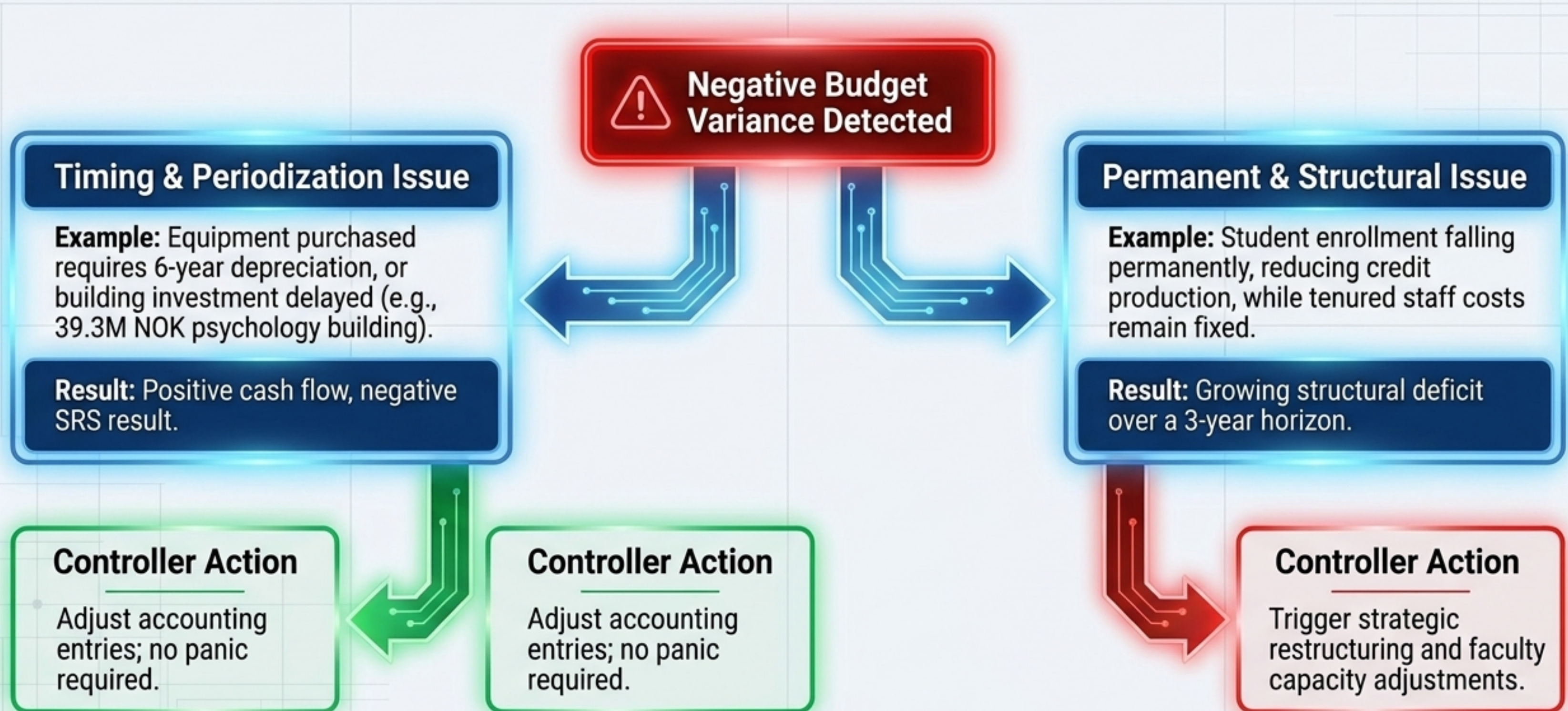


The Core Workflow: Translating Raw Data into Targeted Action



The Controller's true value is created here—moving beyond reporting the weather to actually navigating the ship.

Diagnosing the Root Cause of Budget Deviations



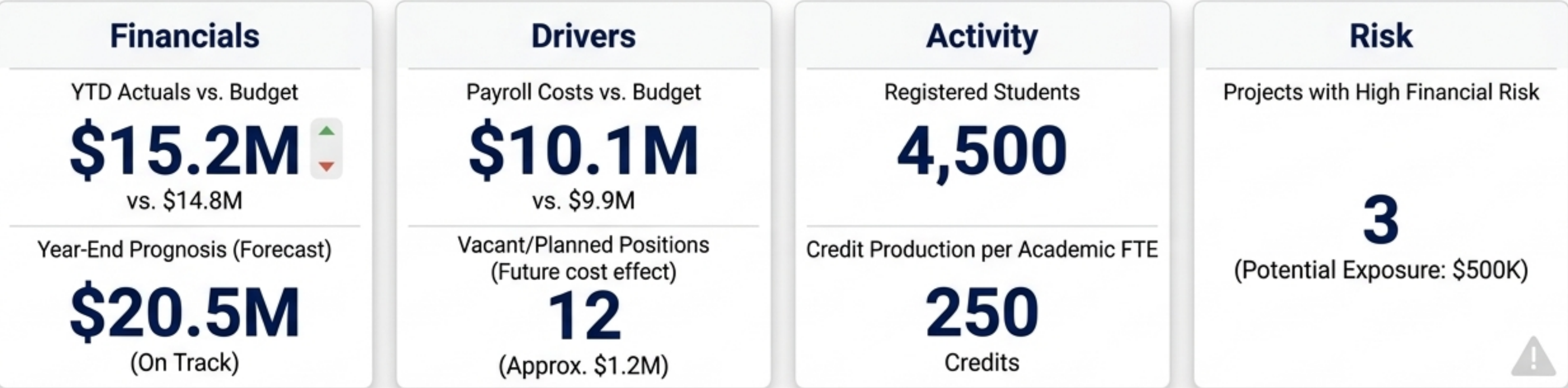
The Information Hierarchy: Matching Granularity to the Audience



Power BI tells leadership where we are. Excel helps the Controller analyze why and model what if.

Dashboard Level 1: Tactical Operations for the Institute Leader

What operational levers must I adjust today?



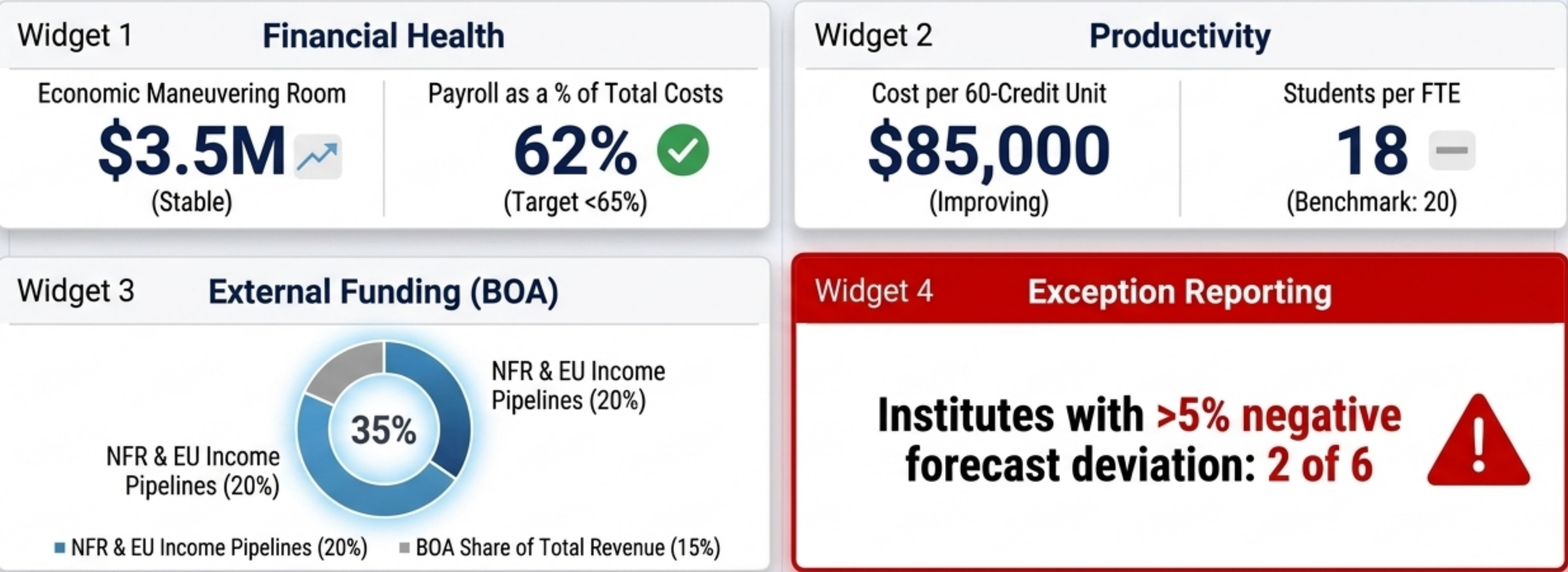
Tactical Drill-Down Table (e.g., By Department, Project, or Faculty)					

Controller Insight

Insight: Institute leaders do not need a 50-line general ledger. They need highly controllable drivers like staffing pipelines and immediate project risks.

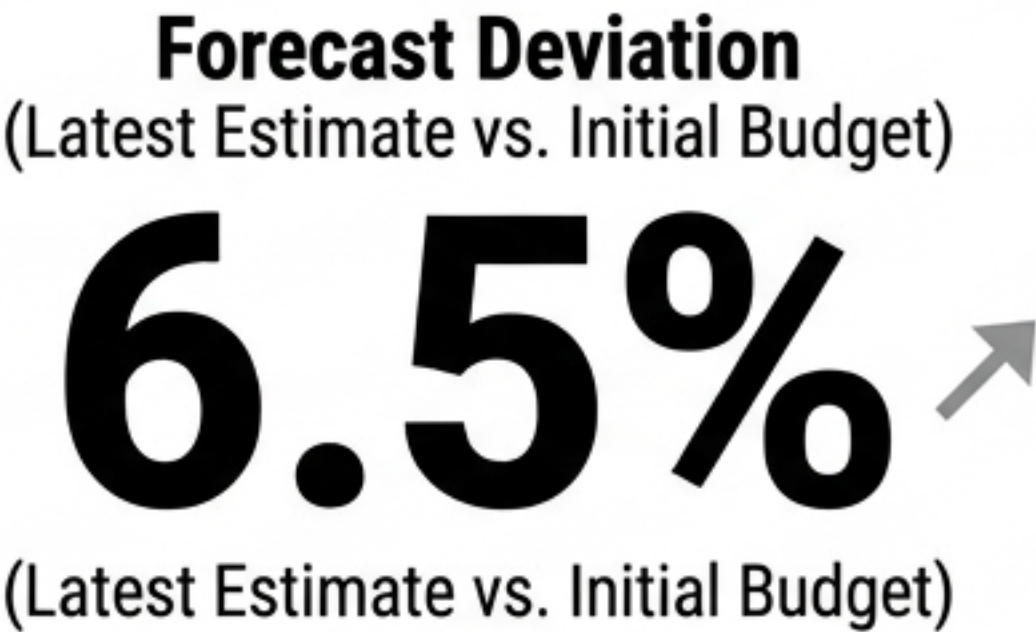
Dashboard Level 2: Structural Health for the Dean & Faculty

Is the Faculty economically sustainable and balanced?



Dashboard Level 3: Aggregate Risk and Control for the Executive Board

Are we in control, and are we mitigating systemic risk?



Total Student Progression



Total External Funding Growth



Critical Financial Risk Areas Identified



Target: 85%+

Dashboard Level 4: The Controller Cockpit and Data Engine

Can we unconditionally trust the data driving our decisions?

1 Forecast Error Margins

Previous vs. Current
(Payroll vs. BOA predictability)



Metric	Previous	Current
Payroll Error	12%	8%
BOA Error	15%	10%

2 Data Hygiene Alerts

- ⚠️ **Un-periodized Entries:** 25 entries (High Risk)
- ⚠️ **Old Open Items:** 42 items >90 days (Medium Risk)
- ⚠️ **Unmapped Accounts:** 7 accounts (Critical)
- ⚠️ **Missing Budgets on Cost Centers:** 3 cost centers (Critical)

Item	Count	Status
Un-periodized	25	High Risk
Old Open	42	Med. Risk
Unmapped Accts	7	Critical
Missing Budgets	3	Critical

3 Project Risks

Projects nearing end-date with large unspent balances

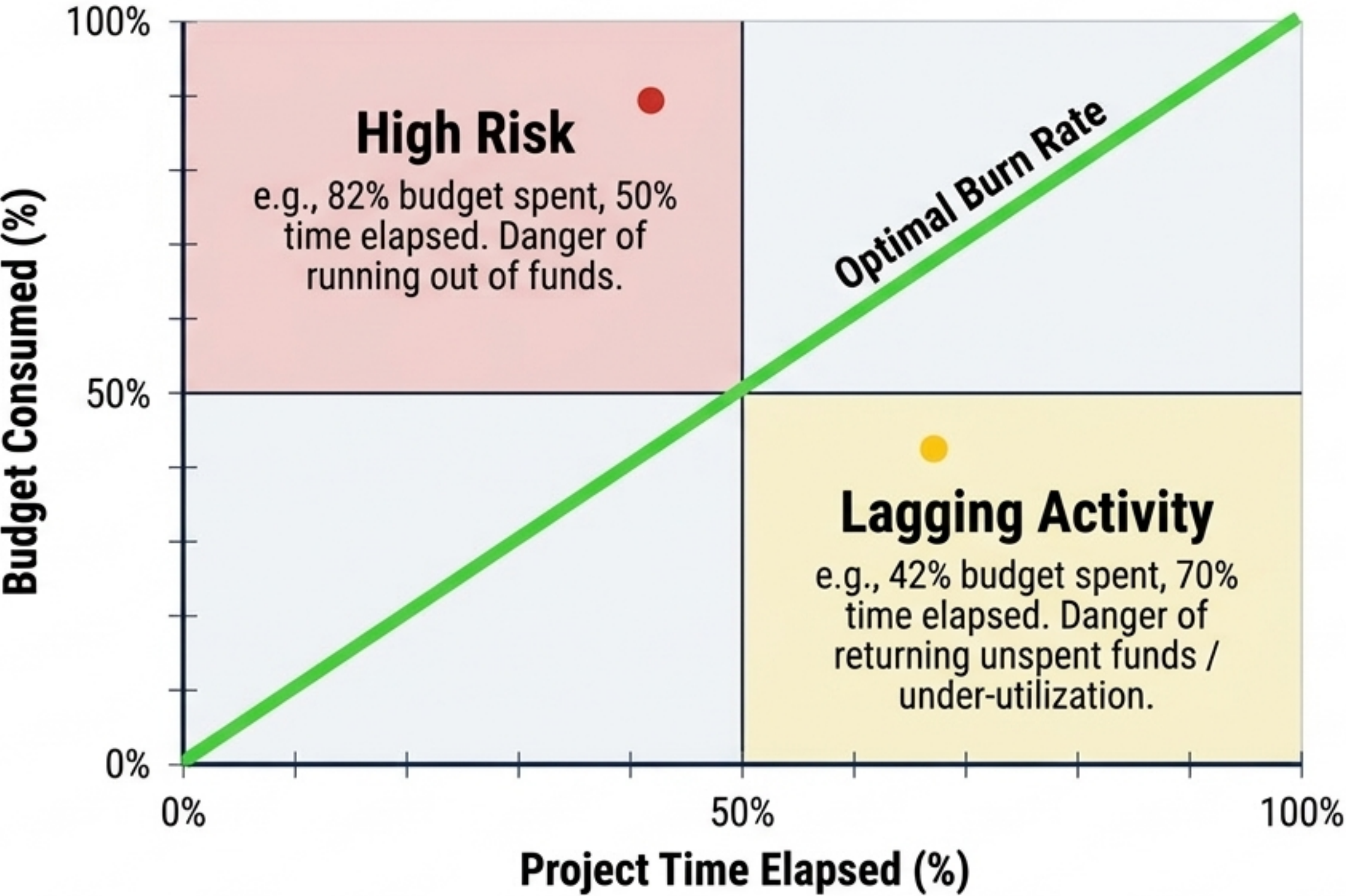
- ⚠️ **Project Alpha:** End Date 12/31, Unspent: \$450K
- ⚠️ **Project Beta:** End Date 01/15, Unspent: \$220K
- ⚠️ **Project Gamma:** End Date 02/28, Unspent: \$180K

Project	End Date	Unspent Bal.
Alpha	12/31	\$450K
Beta	01/15	\$220K
Gamma	02/28	\$180K

Controller Insight

This is the engine room. A strong controller report relies on identifying booking errors and missing periodizations before they corrupt leadership's view.

Earned Value Management for Externally Funded Projects (BOA)



Key Metrics

 **Total Funding**

 **UiA's Self-Financing Requirements**

 **Overhead/Indirect Cost Recovery (TDI)**

The FactAction Framework: Tracking and Quantifying Solutions

Institute	Forecast Deviation	Identified Actions	Expected Financial Effect	Realized Effect	Residual Deviation (Risk)
Institute A	+4.8M Deficit	Hiring freeze & delayed IT purchase	-3.2M	-1.5M (so far)	+1.6M (Remaining Risk)

Takeaway:
A strong Controller does not just highlight red numbers; they quantify the impact of proposed solutions and track their realization in real-time.

The Three Pillars of Modern Financial Management

Strategic Financial Management at Universitetet i Agder

System Mastery

Deep technical understanding of SRS, BOTT/Unit4, and periodization logic to guarantee absolute data integrity.

Business Acumen

Understanding the economic engine—how KD funding, student credits, and external research (BOA) drive institutional revenue.

Decision Support

Moving beyond backward-looking accounting to provide actionable, forward-looking forecasts, scenario models, and risk mitigation strategies.